

2. PenPoint and the Windows XP Tablet Edition

The next significant entrant into the tablet market was GO Computing. GO built an operating system called PenPoint, which was built from ground up to take advantage of the pen-based input system. They also added an add-on for Windows 3.x called Windows for Pen Computing and tablet users could dual boot between GO's own OS or Windows 3.x. Pen Windows was licensed by Microsoft and eventually evolved into Windows XP Tablet Edition.

The Windows XP Tablet Edition PCs used an advanced handwriting recognition software that only got better with time. It used a machine learning algorithm to actually “learn” your style of writing, and store the text without converting it. All the text written by the user could be searched, edited and annotated like one would normally do on paper, without the need for any form of conversion. The platform looked solid on paper, and a number of ‘hybrid’ devices arrived – essentially laptops with screens that could accept pen-based inputs and would swivel around to reveal a tablet.

3. Apple's Newton platform

Not to be left behind, Apple debuted the Apple Newton platform with the MessagePad line of devices, a PDA (Personal Digital Assistant) that was far ahead of its time. The Newton shed many of the traditional desktop paradigms that one was used to, such as manually saving files or a hierarchical file system. It was marketed towards professionals who would be required to sketch or quickly take notes, such as architects, designers and doctors. The device had a screen that was sensitive to stylus input, and was complemented by a slew of productivity applications including a notes, calendar and contacts application. Later versions came with a Calculator, unit converter, word processor and a spreadsheet application. Apple enabled the device to import or export files between equivalent desktop applications using the PIM (Personal Information Manager) format. Data was stored in databases called ‘soups’, and these soups could be shared between applications, so the calendar application could



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